Opus Dei: A Comprehensive Research Document

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With Addendum: Members in Government, Lobbies, Industries, and Power Structures

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What This Document Is

This document is the product of extensive research into Opus Dei — the Prelature of the Holy Cross and Opus Dei — a Catholic organization founded in Spain in 1928 that has grown into one of the most influential, controversial, and secretive religious bodies in the world. What follows is not an opinion piece, not a defense, and not an indictment. It is a compilation of facts, allegations, official statements, court documents, journalistic investigations, and historical records, organized so that a reader with no prior knowledge can understand what Opus Dei is, how it operates, what has been alleged against it, and what remains unknown.

Every claim in this document is sourced from publicly available information: court filings, Vatican documents, newspaper investigations, books by journalists and former members, official Opus Dei publications, and financial records. Where something is an allegation rather than a proven fact, it is labeled as such. Where something is an official statement from Opus Dei, it is presented as such. The goal is completeness — not concision. If a detail matters, it is here.

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Part I: What Is Opus Dei?

The Name and the Basic Idea

"Opus Dei" is Latin for "Work of God." It was founded by a Spanish priest named Josemaría Escrivá de Balaguer on October 2, 1928, in Madrid. Escrivá claimed that while on a spiritual retreat, he received what he described as "the unexpected eruption of a divine light" — the idea that ordinary people, not just priests and nuns, could achieve sainthood through their everyday work. A banker could become a saint by being an excellent banker. A mother could become a saint by being an excellent mother. A lawyer could become a saint by being an excellent lawyer. This was not a new theological concept, but Escrivá built an entire organization around it.

The core idea is called the "universal call to holiness" — the belief that every person, regardless of their state in life, is called to become a saint. Opus Dei members are expected to integrate their faith into every aspect of their daily lives: their jobs, their families, their social circles. They are not monks who withdraw from the world; they are meant to be "in the world but not of it."

The Personal Prelature — What That Means

In 1982, Pope John Paul II made Opus Dei something the Catholic Church had never had before: a "personal prelature." To understand what this means, you need to understand how the Catholic Church is normally organized.

The Church is divided geographically into dioceses — each led by a bishop who has authority over all Catholics in that territory.

A bishop in New York has authority over Catholics in New York. A bishop in Rome has authority over Catholics in Rome. This is territorial jurisdiction.

A personal prelature is different. It has jurisdiction over people, not places. The head of Opus Dei — the Prelate — has authority over Opus Dei members no matter where they live. An Opus Dei member in Tokyo, an Opus Dei member in Nairobi, and an Opus Dei member in New York are all under the authority of the same Prelate in Rome. They do not need to ask permission from the local bishop to operate in that bishop's territory. This is a unique arrangement that gives Opus Dei extraordinary freedom of movement.

The personal prelature was established by Pope John Paul II through an Apostolic Constitution called *Ut Sit* on November 28, 1982. It was implemented on March 19, 1983, alongside the new Code of Canon Law. The canons that govern personal prelatures are Canons 294–297.

The Problem with the Personal Prelature

Here is where things get complicated — and this matters for understanding many of the controversies that follow.

Under canon law, a personal prelature is technically an organization for clergy — priests and deacons. Laypeople can "cooperate organically" with it, but they are not formally part of it in a juridical sense. This means that the vast majority of Opus Dei members — the laypeople — exist in a kind of legal limbo within the Church. They are subject to the Prelate's authority in spiritual matters, but they have no formal recourse or protection under

Church law as members of the prelature.

This was by design. Cardinal Joseph Ratzinger — the future Pope Benedict XVI — was involved in crafting the legal framework. The result is that Opus Dei can exercise enormous control over its lay members while those members have very little institutional protection.

In 2022, Pope Francis issued a motu proprio (a papal decree) called *Ad charisma tuendum* — "To safeguard the charism." He transferred oversight of Opus Dei from the Congregation for Bishops to the Dicastery for the Clergy. He decreed that the head of Opus Dei can no longer be made a bishop — breaking a tradition that had existed since the organization's founding. He also required Opus Dei to submit annual reports to the Vatican instead of every five years.

Francis said publicly: "A form of government based on charism more than on hierarchical authority is needed." He also said, "I am a very good friend of Opus Dei, I love them very much and they work well in the Church." But the changes were significant. In 2023, he issued another motu proprio modifying Canons 295 and 296, further defining the prelate as a "moderator endowed with faculties of an ordinary" and emphasizing that laypeople remain fully subject to their local bishops.

In 2025, Opus Dei submitted a third set of revised statutes to the Vatican. They were rejected. According to reports, the current Prelate, Fernando Ocáriz, had been arguing that canon law was flexible enough to allow laypeople to be formally part of the personal prelature. The Vatican disagreed. The only canonical fix, according to experts, would be to create a separate association

for the laity under the Dicastery for Laity and Family Life — something Ocáriz has reportedly resisted. A leaked meditation allegedly had Ocáriz telling regional vicars at Easter that he was "waiting for the pope to die."

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Part II: The Founder — Josemaría Escrivá

Early Life

Josemaría Escrivá de Balaguer was born on January 9, 1902, in Barbastro, a town in the province of Huesca in northern Spain. He was the second of six children. His father, José Escrivá, was a textile merchant. His mother, Dolores Albás, came from a family of modest means.

The family suffered a devastating financial blow in 1915 when José Escrivá's business went bankrupt. They were forced to relocate to Logroño, a city in the La Rioja region. It was there, as a teenager, that Josemaría reportedly saw the footprints of a barefoot monk in the snow — an image that awakened his desire for the priesthood.

He was ordained a deacon on December 20, 1924, and a priest on March 28, 1925, in Zaragoza. He studied civil law at the University of Zaragoza and received his licentiate in 1927. That same year, he moved to Madrid for graduate studies. His father had died in 1924, so Josemaría supported his mother, sister, and brother by tutoring law students.

In Madrid, he took on pastoral care for the sick, the poor, and manual laborers. University students began to join him. On

October 2, 1928, during a spiritual retreat at the Vincentian headquarters in Madrid, he claimed to have received what he later described as "the unexpected eruption of a divine light" — the inspiration to found Opus Dei. He was 26 years old.

The First Members and the Name

Initially, the organization had no name. The name "Opus Dei" came from a conversation with his Jesuit spiritual director, Father Valentín Sánchez Ruiz, who asked how "that work of God" was going. The first member was admitted in June 1929 — a student from Zaragoza named José Romeo. The first woman was admitted on February 14, 1930. Escrivá claimed that during Mass, God showed him that Opus Dei was for women too.

The first center opened in 1933: the DYA Academy in Madrid, offering classes in law and architecture mainly for students.

The Priestly Society of the Holy Cross

On February 14, 1943, Escrivá claimed another divine inspiration during Mass — this time, the juridical solution for ordaining priests specifically for Opus Dei. The Priestly Society of the Holy Cross was established. The first three priests were ordained on June 25, 1944: Álvaro del Portillo, José María Hernández Garnica, and José Luis Múzquiz — all engineers by profession. The ordinations were performed by the Bishop of Madrid, Leopoldo Eijo y Garay.

Personality and Temperament

Escrivá's personality is a matter of significant dispute. His supporters describe him as a warm, fatherly figure with a deep spiritual vision. His critics — including some former members — describe him as ill-tempered, arrogant, and authoritarian.

Multiple sources, including historians and former members, have described Escrivá as having a difficult temperament. Some former members who testified during his canonization process said he was unworthy of sainthood. The Swiss theologian Hans Urs von Balthasar reportedly dismissed Escrivá's most famous book, *The Way*, as a "handbook for senior scouts" — though von Balthasar later clarified that many accusations against Opus Dei were "simply false and anti-clerical."

Escrivá's writings contain passages that have been cited by critics as evidence of an authoritarian streak:

- "Blessed be pain. Loved be pain. Sanctified be pain. . . Glorified be pain!" (*The Way*, 208)
- "No ideal becomes a reality without sacrifice. Deny yourself. It is so beautiful to be a victim!" (*The Way*, 175)
- "Obey with your lips, your heart and your mind. It is not a man who is being obeyed, but God." (*Furrow*, 374)

These passages are presented by Opus Dei as spiritual exhortations about accepting suffering and obedience to God. Critics read them as instructions for unconditional submission to human authority.

Death and Canonization

Escrivá died on June 26, 1975, in Rome. His death was reported by Opus Dei as occurring at midday. (Gareth Gore's book claimed it was before midnight; Opus Dei's rebuttal corrected this detail.)

His canonization was one of the most controversial in modern Vatican history. Pope John Paul II canonized him on October 6, 2002, in St. Peter's Square before a crowd of over 300,000 people. It was just 27 years after his death — one of the shortest waiting times in Vatican history.

The controversy centered on several issues:

- The lack of Spanish judges on the canonization panel.
- The fact that Opus Dei doctors were the ones who certified his miracles.
- Allegations from former members about his temperament and behavior.
- The perception that John Paul II fast-tracked the process because of his strong support for Opus Dei.

In March 2026, journalist Gareth Gore met with Pope Leo XIV and urged him to reopen the beatification and canonization process, presenting documents that he claimed showed "potential irregularities" and proved that "Opus Dei's system of grooming, abuse and control had been personally designed by this supposed 'saint'."

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Part III: Structure and Membership

The Five Categories of Membership

Opus Dei has a complex, tiered membership structure. Understanding these categories is essential to understanding how the organization functions and where many of the controversies arise.

1. Numeraries

Numeraries are celibate lay members who live in Opus Dei centers — communal residences owned or controlled by the organization. They are fully dedicated to what Opus Dei calls "apostolic work" — recruiting new members, running formation programs, and managing the organization's activities. They are expected to work in professional jobs outside the centers (unless they are priests), but their lives are entirely organized around Opus Dei.

There are about 25,000 celibate members total, both men and women. This includes numeraries, associates, and numerary assistants.

2. Associates

Associates are also celibate, but they have permanent personal, family, or professional obligations that prevent them from living in centers full-time. They usually live with their own families or in their own homes. They have the same spiritual duties as numeraries where applicable.

3. Supernumeraries

Supernumeraries are the vast majority of Opus Dei's roughly 90,000 members. They are married or single laypeople who

participate in Opus Dei activities — attending retreats, receiving spiritual direction from Opus Dei priests, participating in formation classes — but they continue to live their normal lives, with their families, in their own homes. Their participation is expected to be compatible with their family and professional responsibilities.

4. Cooperators

Cooperators are not members. They are people who support Opus Dei through prayer, financial donations, or volunteer work. They have no juridical bond to the organization and are not subject to its internal rules.

5. Numerary Assistants

This is the most controversial category and the one at the center of the human trafficking allegations. Numerary assistants are women only. They are dedicated to what Opus Dei calls "caring for people and activities linked to the Prelature" — which means cooking, cleaning, doing laundry, and maintaining chapel linens in Opus Dei centers. They live under obedience, commit to celibacy, and their lives are entirely controlled by the organization.

In men's centers, the numerary assistants are called "the Administration." They are the only point of overlap between the male and female branches of Opus Dei. The separation between men and women is almost total.

Gender Separation

Men's and women's branches operate as entirely separate organizations. There are only two points of overlap:

1. Opus Dei priests, who are part of the men's branch, give spiritual direction to women members.
2. The numerary assistants, who are part of the women's branch, perform domestic work in men's centers.

The protocols for interaction are extraordinarily strict. In men's centers:

- Doors between male and female areas are locked from both sides.
- Men must stay out of sleeping quarters and dining rooms when women are present.
- Men are never allowed in the kitchen while women are there.
- All notes passed between male and female sides are read by two people.
- Phone calls between men and women must be brief, and another person must be present.

Female numeraries eat separately from numerary assistants — the assistants wait upon them.

The Contract and the Vows

Before 1982, members of Opus Dei took private vows of obedience, poverty, and chastity. These were not public religious vows like those taken by monks and nuns, but they were binding spiritual commitments.

Since 1982, the system has changed. Members now sign a formal contract or declaration. The Prelature promises spiritual formation and pastoral care. The member promises to seek holiness, carry out apostolic work, and remain under the Prelate's jurisdiction.

To become a full member requires a probationary period of at least 5 years. Opus Dei claims that members must express their consent at multiple stages — at least 8 written reaffirmations over a minimum of 6.5 years. Members must reaffirm their desire to remain at least 8 times.

Critics argue that this system creates enormous psychological pressure. A person who has invested 5–7 years of their life, who has cut ties with outside friends, who has given their salary to the organization, and who believes their spiritual salvation depends on staying, is not truly free to leave — regardless of what the contract says on paper.

Governance — Who Is in Charge

The Prelate is elected by an all-male electoral congress. The congress has 156 members, 62 of whom are lay electors. However, lay electors are not eligible to become Prelate themselves — only priests can hold that position. Women can suggest candidates, but their vote is not binding. Opus Dei claims the women's vote has "important consultation value," but the power to elect the leader rests entirely with men.

The current Prelate is Monsignor Fernando Ocáriz, appointed January 23, 2017, by Pope Francis. He is the fourth Prelate after Escrivá.

Previous Prelates:

- Josemaría Escrivá (founder, 1928–1975)
- Álvaro del Portillo (1975–1994)
- Javier Echevarría Rodríguez (1994–2016)

Ocáriz is a theologian who taught at the Pontifical University of the Holy Cross in Rome. He was a consultant to the Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith under Cardinal Ratzinger (future Pope Benedict XVI) starting in 1986.

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Part IV: Spiritual Practices and Corporal Mortification

What Is Corporal Mortification?

Corporal mortification is the practice of inflicting physical discomfort or pain on oneself as a form of spiritual discipline. It has a long history in Catholicism — saints like Francis of Assisi, Ignatius of Loyola, and Thérèse of Lisieux are known to have practiced various forms of it. The idea is that by voluntarily accepting physical suffering, a person can grow closer to Christ, who suffered on the cross, and can overcome sinful tendencies.

Opus Dei has been criticized for promoting and, in some cases, requiring corporal mortification practices that critics say are excessive and harmful.

Documented Practices

The Cilice

A cilice is a small spiked metal chain worn around the upper thigh. Opus Dei members who use it wear it for two hours daily, except on Church feast days, Sundays, and certain liturgical seasons. The spikes press into the flesh, leaving small prick marks. It is used by some celibate members — both men and

women.

Opus Dei defends this practice by pointing out that it has been used by saints for centuries and that it causes only "a low level of discomfort comparable to fasting." Critics counter that wearing a spiked chain against your skin for two hours a day is not comparable to skipping a meal.

The Discipline

The discipline is a cord-like whip used on the buttocks or back, typically once a week. Members need permission to use it more frequently. According to some accounts, Escrivá himself was so zealous in its use that he "splattered the bathroom walls with streaks of blood."

Cold Showers

Most numeraries take cold showers daily, offering up the discomfort for the intentions of the current Prelate.

Meal Mortifications

These include drinking coffee without milk or sugar, not buttering toast, skipping dessert, not taking seconds, and not eating between meals.

Sleep Practices

Female numeraries sleep on boards laid on top of their mattresses. Male numeraries sleep on the floor once a week. Both sleep without a pillow once a week.

Gender Differences in Practice

Male numeraries are allowed to smoke and go to bars — ostensibly to recruit new members in social settings. Female numeraries may not smoke or enter bars. Escrivá reportedly believed that "women had passions that required more discipline

to tame."

The Da Vinci Code Effect

Dan Brown's 2003 novel *The Da Vinci Code* and its 2006 film adaptation portrayed Opus Dei as a murderous, ultraconservative secret society. The portrayal was fictional and sensationalized, but it had a real impact on public perception.

A 2008 ORB poll in Britain found that readers of *The Da Vinci Code* were four times more likely to think of Opus Dei as a "murderous sect." Seventeen percent of readers believed Opus Dei had ordered or carried out a murder, compared to 4% of non-readers.

Opus Dei was careful to avoid protests and boycotts of the film while taking advantage of the notoriety to increase its visibility. Jack Valero, an Opus Dei spokesman in the UK, said: "Since we were founded in 1928 Opus Dei has promoted the highest moral standards at work, spreading a message of Christian love and understanding, yet the Da Vinci Code has persuaded hundreds of thousands of people that we have blood on our hands."

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Part V: Recruitment Methods and Criticisms

How Recruitment Works

Opus Dei recruits through what it calls "apostolate" — spiritual outreach. Critics call it targeted recruitment with sophisticated psychological techniques. The truth lies somewhere in the documented evidence.

Documented Recruitment Tactics:

- **Targeting the young and impressionable**: Recruiters focus on teenagers and young adults, particularly those who are spiritually seeking, socially isolated, or going through difficult transitions (starting college, moving to a new city, experiencing family problems).
- **Friendship as bait**: Recruiters are instructed to befriend targets first. The initial contact is not presented as a recruitment pitch. It is presented as friendship, mentorship, or spiritual guidance.
- **Social activities not advertised as Opus Dei events**: Potential recruits are invited to dinners, retreats, sports activities, or study groups without being told these are Opus Dei activities.
- **Expensively appointed houses**: Recruitment often happens in well-appointed residences in desirable neighborhoods — places that feel safe, welcoming, and aspirational.
- **Atmosphere of delight**: Former members describe an atmosphere designed to be irresistible — "laughter, whistling, macho behaviour and good-humoured raillery."

- **Targeting traditional families**: Opus Dei particularly seeks recruits from families that still live by traditional religious principles. They want "well bred and educated people."
- **The "whistling" system**: Children aged 14.5 or older can become "junior candidates" by writing a letter to the head of Opus Dei. This is internally known as "whistling" — the sound of the letter being sent. It requires express parental consent as a rule of prudence, but junior candidates are not formal members and continue living with their parents.

Allegations of Pressure and Control

Former members and critics allege that once a person shows interest, the pressure escalates:

- **Love bombing**: Potential recruits are showered with flattery, attention, and admiration.
- **Gradual isolation**: Members slowly break ties with outside friends and family. Letters and phone calls are censored or monitored. Reading material is controlled.
- **Financial control**: Members give their entire salaries to Opus Dei. They must ask permission for even small personal purchases.
- **The "engagements"**: Members commit to Opus Dei through formal "engagements" — often without their parents' knowledge.
- **Mail scrutiny**: Incoming and outgoing mail is read by directors.

The ODAN Network

The Opus Dei Awareness Network (ODAN) was founded in 1991 by Tammy DiNicola's mother after Tammy left Opus Dei. ODAN provides information and support to people who believe they have been harmed by Opus Dei. It documents concerns about corporal mortification, aggressive recruitment, undue pressure, environmental control, and alienation from families.

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Part VI: The Spanish Civil War and the Franco Era

Surviving the War

When the Spanish Civil War broke out in 1936, Opus Dei was tiny — about 30 members, most living in the Republican zone (the anti-Franco, leftist-controlled area). Escrivá swapped his priest's cassock for worker's blue overalls, put on his father's wedding ring, and went into hiding. He took refuge in eight different houses and hid in a psychiatric sanatorium for a time. Four members were confined to prison. Escrivá spent months hidden in the Honduran consulate in Madrid.

He feared being killed like other clergy. Thousands of priests, monks, and nuns were murdered by Republican forces during the war.

Post-War Expansion

Francisco Franco's victory in 1939 created what historians describe as "the perfect conditions" for Opus Dei's expansion. Franco made religious classes compulsory and encouraged religious orders to create student residences. The Catholic Church became a pillar of the Franco regime.

Escrivá wrote in a letter dated April 27, 1939: "I believe that we will have to bless the war." He and his deputy, Álvaro del Portillo, had contacts with Franco, who had expressed "several times" his "sincere desire" to help Opus Dei.

The Technocrats

In the 1950s, several Opus Dei members joined Franco's government. The most notable were Rafael Calvo Serer and Alberto Ullastres. They helped modernize Spain's economy during the reforms of 1957–1959, shifting Spain from economic autarchy (self-sufficiency) toward liberalization and international trade. Ullastres pushed forward the Plan of Stabilization.

This earned Opus Dei a reputation as a conservative power broker. Critics labeled it a deliberate infiltration of the government; Opus Dei insisted that its members acted as individuals, not as representatives of the organization.

The dossier is complicated by the fact that some Opus Dei members opposed Franco. Antonio Fontán, an Opus Dei member, was a journalist who advocated for free elections and trade unions and was persecuted by Franco. He later helped draft Spain's democratic constitution after Franco's death. Rafael Calvo Serer also opposed the Franco regime from within Spain and later from

exile in Paris.

Documented Opus Dei Members in Franco's Government

- **Alberto Ullastres Calvo** (1914–2001): Minister of Trade (1957–1965). Pushed forward the Plan of Stabilization.
- **Gregorio López Bravo**: Minister for Industry (1963–1969), Minister of Foreign Affairs (1969–1973).
- **Juan José Espinosa San Martín** (1918–1982): Minister for Finance (1965–1969).
- **Faustino García-Moncó Fernández** (1916–1996): Minister for Trade (1965–1969).
- **Vicente Mortes Alfonso** (1921–1991): Minister for Housing (1969–1973).
- **Fernando Herrero Tejedor** (1920–1975): Secretary General of the Movimiento (Franco's political party) in 1975.

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Part VII: Finances, Real Estate, and Banco Popular

The Scale of Opus Dei's Wealth

Opus Dei does not publish consolidated financial statements. Its assets are held through a complex web of foundations, nonprofit organizations, and affiliated entities in dozens of countries. What follows is a partial picture assembled from public records, investigative journalism, and court documents.

Banco Popular and the Collapse of 2017

On June 7, 2017, Banco Popular — Spain's fifth-largest bank, with a 90-year history — collapsed overnight. It was sold to Banco Santander for the symbolic sum of €1 (about $1.20). It was one of the largest bank failures in European history.

The bank's chairman from 1972 to 2004 was Luis Valls-Taberner, a lifelong Opus Dei numerary. He died in 2006. His brother, Javier Valls, also had ties to the bank.

Journalist Gareth Gore, who was assigned to report on the bank's collapse, discovered what he describes as a "clandestine network of foundations and companies" funneling money from the bank to Opus Dei.

The "Balance Sheet of International Cooperation"

On his third visit to the Banco Popular archives in northern Spain, Gore found a document in an "unofficial" archive — a collection discovered in a mansion in the mountains outside Madrid where Valls-Taberner had lived. An archivist had been sent to recover this "stray" collection and found that someone had been there before to purge it — but had missed this document.

The document, titled "Balance Sheet of International Cooperation," linked Banco Popular to more than 60 seemingly innocuous companies around the world. During the late 1980s and early 1990s, tens of millions of dollars were sent all over the world. The records were kept separate from the official Banco Popular archives.

Recipients were in countries including Australia, Cameroon, Ireland, Nigeria, and the Philippines. Many of these companies ran "vocational schools" similar to those implicated in the

Argentine scandal. Gore alleges this was a "vast operation to entrap these young girls and then traffic them to work in the service of Opus Dei all around the world — and all of it financed by Banco Popular."

La Sindicatura ("The Syndicate")

Gore discovered an enigmatically named group called "La Sindicatura" that held 10% of the bank when it went bankrupt — a stake valued at over €2 billion ($2.2 billion) at its peak. A few weeks after the bankruptcy, La Sindicatura's main company notified authorities of its dissolution.

Gore alleges it was a "fake" syndicate — a ruse where big shareholders' votes were double-counted (as individuals AND as syndicate members) to swing important votes and prevent accountability. According to a source identified as "Javier" (brother of a former executive), "it was all fake... they double-counted those of us in The Syndicate."

The Foundations

Valls-Taberner created three charitable foundations:

- Fundación Hispánica
- Fomento de Fundaciones
- Fundación Patronato Universitario

Opus Dei's rebuttal states that these foundations provided donations and grants totaling €208 million and loans of €557 million. They claim 90% of loans were fully repaid and 10% were still being repaid, with €62 million outstanding in 2023. They deny that Fundación Hispánica funded schools in Spain and note that a loan of €120,000 for a summer camp called "Las Cabañas" in 1977 was fully repaid.

Opus Dei denies owning any companies. They claim the institutions are "promoted by members" with "formative and spiritual orientation" agreements. They also claim that board members "renounced being paid" and that Valls-Taberner's donations were "personal donations."

Opus Dei spokesperson Yago de la Cierva stated: "To attribute to him the disappearance of the bank thirteen years after his leaving the presidency and eleven years after his death is not only absurd; it is also despicable."

US Real Estate and Foundations

Opus Dei owns or controls extensive real estate in the United States through a network of foundations. Gore has claimed that Opus Dei is opening 40 new schools around the US. The following is a partial list of documented US foundation assets based on public tax records:

New York:

- National Center Foundation: $69.5 million (Opus Dei North American Headquarters at Murray Hill Place, 243 Lexington Avenue)
- Pontifical Atheneum of the Holy Cross Foundation: $16.3 million
- Woodlawn Foundation: $14.9 million
- Heights Foundation: $3.8 million

New Jersey:

- Association for Cultural Interchange: $62.6 million
- Clover Foundation: $26.3 million

Massachusetts:

- Arnold Hall: $7.5 million
- Montrose Foundation: $2.2 million

California:

- Association for Educational Development-California: $5.6 million
- Tilden Study Center: $2.5 million
- Trumbull Manor: $2.5 million
- Peninsula Foundation: $1.7 million
- Menlough Study Center: $1.3 million

Virginia:

- Wyoming House (Georgetown area): $8.1 million
- Longlea Conference Center: 844-acre estate purchased for $7.4 million in 2001 (anonymous donor supplied entire purchase price)
- Tysons (Reston) Study Center: $1.2 million

Texas:

- Chaucer Drive Study Center (Rice University): $676,529
- Featherock Conference Center: $1.2 million
- Southgate Foundation: $1.1 million
- Southmore Foundation: $584,270

Illinois:

- Corporation for Social and Educational Development: $2.9 million
- Lexington Center: $1,245
- Lexington College: $263,288 (the only women's hospitality institution in the U.S. for the economically challenged)

Indiana:

- Shellbourne: $6.8 million

Pennsylvania:

- Warwick Foundation: $802,047

Rhode Island:

- Mathewson Foundation: $510,161

Ohio:

- The Mary Foundation: $477,435

Wisconsin:

- Layton Study Center: $857,144

Florida:

- Kingsland Foundation: $559,444
- Roseaire: $661,156

Washington, DC:

- Catholic Information Center (CIC)
- Tenley Study Center: $381,100
- Van Ness Study Center: $25,596
- Stonecrest Home Arts: $47,688

The total documented assets of listed US foundations alone exceed $200 million. This does not include the value of the real estate itself, which in many cases (particularly in Manhattan, Georgetown, and Princeton) is worth far more than the foundation's listed assets.

International Properties

Rome:

- Villa Tevere: The central headquarters in the Parioli hills, purchased from Count Mario Gori Mazzoleni. Built on land that had belonged to the Sacchetti family since 1850. The "Vigna Sacchetti" once covered about 50 hectares.

United Kingdom:

- Dawliffe Hall (London)
- Netherhall House (London)
- Greygarth Hall (Manchester)
- Ashwell House (London)
- Kelston Club and Study Centre (London)

Ireland:

- Ros Geal University Residence (Galway)
- Ballyglunin Park (County Galway)

Australia:

- Dartbrooke Study Centre (Sydney)
- Eremeran Club (Sydney)
- Kenthurst Study Centre

Chile:

- Residencia Araucaria (Santiago)

Colombia:

- Universidad de La Sabana (Chía, Cundinamarca)

Kenya:

- Strathmore University (Nairobi)

Nigeria:

- Lagoon School (Lagos)

Congo:

- Monkole Hospital

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Part VIII: The Argentine Human Trafficking Case

The Accusation

In 2022, a lawyer named Sebastián Sal — himself a former member of Opus Dei — filed a complaint on behalf of 43 women. Argentine prosecutors concluded that from the early 1970s until 2015, "people holding different positions within Opus Dei established a structure dedicated to recruiting at least 44 women, most of them girls and adolescents, to be subjected to living conditions comparable to servitude."

The prosecutors who reached this conclusion were:

- **Eduardo Taiano**, head of the national prosecutor's office
- **María Alejandra Mángano**, co-head of the Office of the Prosecutor for Human Trafficking and Exploitation
- **Marcelo Colombo**, co-head of the same office

The women were recruited from low-income families in several South American countries. They were promised job training and education. Instead, they were placed in grueling domestic work.

The Accused

Five priests who led the organization over the years have been named:

1. **Carlos Nannei** — Vicar General of Opus Dei in Argentina, 1990–2000
2. **Patricio Olmos** — Regional Vicar General, 2000–2010
3. **Víctor Urrestarazu** — Regional Vicar, 2014

4. **Gabriel Dondo** — Former director of the women's branch in Argentina
5. **Mariano Fazio** — Current auxiliary vicar of Opus Dei worldwide (the #2 authority in the organization). He was Regional Vicar of Argentina from 2010–2014. He was ordained by Pope John Paul II in 1991. He holds a degree in history from the University of Buenos Aires and a doctorate in philosophy from the Pontifical University of the Holy Cross. He served as first dean of institutional communications at the Pontifical University of the Holy Cross (1996–2002) and as rector (2002–2008).

In July 2025, prosecutors asked that Fazio also be called to testify. The plaintiff's lawyer also requested the inclusion of Monsignor Fernando Ocáriz — the current Prelate of Opus Dei worldwide — in the investigation.

The Complainant

The case is legally centered on the testimony of a Bolivian woman who worked for Opus Dei for 30 years. In April 2025, she expanded her statement claiming to have directly served Fazio, among other priests. Due to statute of limitations restrictions, the case is built around her testimony, though prosecutors reference 44 women total.

Specific Allegations

- Women were recruited from low-income, rural families through a "deceitful selection" that took "advantage of their extreme vulnerability."

- They were "enticed" by promises of education and job opportunities.
- They were "trapped in a cycle of exploitation and abuse," working 14-hour days with barely any rest.
- They did not receive salaries — money was given to the organization instead.
- They had no Social Security registration — a specific labor law violation.
- Access to medical care and the outside world was heavily controlled.
- The system involved "indoctrination and psychological manipulation" with "rules of life."
- Women were obligated to chastity, had to sever family and social ties, and were given periodic health check-ups and psychiatric medication under threat of punishment.

Opus Dei Argentina's Response

Opus Dei Argentina opened a "listening commission" in 2022. Catalina Maria Donnelly, director of the female branch in Argentina, acknowledged "informality" in remuneration: "Maybe the woman running the residence had a common cash box and from there all the expenses were met." She said that today it would be considered "badly done, but at that time it was done as it was done in families." She expressed openness to ask for forgiveness and financially compensate each woman based on their specific situation.

Opus Dei Global Response

Opus Dei's global communications office "categorically" denies human trafficking and labor exploitation. They claim the complaint stems from a "complete decontextualisation" of the assistant numerary vocation. They say the woman was referring to a stage when she "freely chose to embark on her spiritual journey."

They emphasize that:

- Members must reaffirm their vocation at least 8 times over 6.5 years.
- Anyone can leave at any time.
- Assistant numeraries' work is "compensated" and is their "professional choice."
- The application of the criminal charge is "an abuse" with "no connection with the facts."
- They accuse the plaintiff's lawyer of "serious abuse of the legal system through the news media" to exert pressure in an "employment-monetary dispute."

Current Status

Federal Judge Daniel Rafecas is reviewing the case. No one has been formally charged. Prosecutors requested that Fazio appear to testify in June 2025. The case remains in the preliminary phase.

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Part IX: The Numerary Assistant System — Global Allegations

The System Itself

Numerary assistants are women only. They are dedicated to domestic work in Opus Dei centers — cooking, cleaning, laundry, chapel linens. They live under obedience, commit to celibacy, and their lives are entirely controlled by the organization.

Opus Dei claims that more than 4,000 women worldwide choose this vocation "with love and commitment." They state that the work is paid: "Like any other job, this work is compensated." They claim it is a "vocation approved by the Catholic Church."

The Financial Times Investigation (2024)

Journalist Antonia Cundy of the Financial Times uncovered accounts of 16 women who accused Opus Dei of "enslavement." They were recruited as young girls from rural and working-class backgrounds on the premise of receiving education. They were coerced into domestic servitude through a "rigid system of psychological control." When they left, they had nothing to their name.

Claudia Carrero's Story:

Carrero was recruited at age 13 in 1979. She was promised training in hotel management. Instead, she was put to work. "They did not take me there to study, but to work... I had no control over anything in my life. I had to ask for permission to call my parents, all our mail was read, we were not allowed to go out alone."

Carrero said she has heard nearly identical stories from women in Mexico, Italy, Poland, Spain, Ireland, Peru, and Chile: "All of us lived the same experiences, identical ones. That is no coincidence."

The Catherine Allen Memoir — "Serve" (2025)

Catherine "Cathy" Allen, a former numerary assistant from Ireland, published the first English-language account of conditions endured by assistant numeraries.

Allen attended a "so-called two-year course" at Ballyglunin Park, County Galway, at age 16. Other girls in the course were being brought to Rome. She was told: "You're to tell your parents you have won a scholarship to go to work in an exclusive center of Opus Dei, and that this is a very unique opportunity."

She wrote to her parents saying she wouldn't be home for Easter, nor going to Rome. "The only reason I was there was because they needed free domestic labor... My parents were lied to. I was told to lie."

She was sent to Dublin, Riversdale Center, at age 17 for 10 days of Easter. She worked from 8 a.m. until 9 p.m. "Seven days a week, morning until night, silently cleaning for no pay, trafficked, enslaved and unhappy."

"I don't remember turning 17, 18, 19 or 20, but I remember going between centers in Ireland, to do the same monotonous duties seven days a week, for years."

She described the uniform when serving male numeraries: black dresses, black hair bands, white aprons, white cuffs, and white collars.

"We were not paid... We had to ask for everything, even small things. Everything was watched and counted, and if you had a special request it would be mulled over like you were asking for a loan of thousands and usually denied: Even things like hairclips were major asks."

She noted that numeraries "had full wardrobes filled with lovely modern clothes... I knew they did, because I cleaned their bedrooms."

She was introduced to mortification by another assistant numerary. She was given a small linen bag containing a discipline ("looked like a horse whip") and a cilice ("metal chain with metal spikes and a clasp... looked like something you would put on an animal... I'd seen something like that on the neck of a dog"). She was told to wear the cilice on her leg for two hours a day. She complied.

Allegations in Ireland and the UK

Five assistant numeraries are pursuing civil claims for personal injury in Ireland and the UK. One woman in Ireland reported allegations (dating from the late 1970s to the mid-1980s) to police.

The Peru Connection

A former director of a hospitality school for girls in Peru told the Financial Times she believed the main purpose of the school was to recruit assistant numeraries. "No interest" in improving education but "a lot of interest in indoctrinating" pupils. "They said the intention was to give them an education, to empower them, but the reality that I saw was the opposite. They were getting free labour to work in their centres."

She left Opus Dei in 2021 after attempts to reform the school were ignored.

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Part X: The Catholic Information Center and US Political Influence

The CIC on K Street

The Catholic Information Center (CIC) is located at 1501 K Street NW in Washington, DC — two blocks from the White House. It bills itself as "the closest tabernacle to the White House." It is entrusted to Opus Dei priests and operates as a diocesan institution staffed by Opus Dei priests by mutual agreement.

Under Father C. John McCloskey, who served as director from 1998 to 2002, the CIC became a central meeting place for high-profile conservative Catholics.

Father C. John McCloskey — The Converter-in-Chief

McCloskey was a former Wall Street broker who became an Opus Dei priest. He became famous for converting prominent conservatives to Catholicism:

- **Newt Gingrich** — Former Speaker of the House
- **Senator Sam Brownback** — Kansas senator, later Governor
- **Judge Robert Bork** — Reagan's failed Supreme Court nominee
- **Larry Kudlow** — Trump's National Economic Council director
- **Robert Novak** — Conservative columnist
- **Dr. Bernard Nathanson** — Founder of NARAL, later pro-life activist
- **Alfred Regnery** — Conservative publisher
- **General Josiah Bunting**
- **Laura Ingraham** — Fox News host (credits Pat Cipollone with her conversion)

McCloskey was a regular commentator on CNN's Crossfire, NBC Nightly News, Dateline, and Meet the Press. He preached against what he called the "culture of death" — contraception, IVF, and abortion.

He famously told senators: "How many constituents do you have?... May I suggest that you have only one constituent?" (referring to God). This reportedly changed Sam Brownback's life.

McCloskey's Downfall

In November 2002, a complaint was received of sexual misconduct against an adult woman during pastoral counseling at the CIC. The woman was in an "emotionally vulnerable state" seeking spiritual support. She was an accomplished professional earning a good salary. She had to leave her job as a result of the abuse.

McCloskey groped her several times while she was discussing marital troubles and depression. She went to confession about it; McCloskey absolved her — a potential violation of Canon 1378, which carries automatic excommunication for hearing the confession of a sexual sin partner.

Opus Dei investigated and found the complaint credible. In December 2003, McCloskey was removed as CIC director. In 2005, Opus Dei paid $977,000 to settle the lawsuit. The money came from a single donor. The settlement included a mutual non-disclosure agreement, though neither side intends to enforce it.

McCloskey was sent to England, then Chicago (2005–2013), then California. The survivor was told he would be on a "very tight leash" and not given faculties to act as a priest. She later learned he may have been working as a priest in California. He died in 2023, suffering from advanced Alzheimer's. After his removal, book reviews continued appearing in Catholic press under his name — he had an editor who helped with writing, and as his condition declined, the editor wrote articles completely.

In 2019, Opus Dei stated they were investigating a possible complaint from another woman. The outcome of that investigation

is unknown.

The "Troika" — Federalist Society + CIC + Opus Dei

A powerful network has been described as operating at the intersection of three institutions: the Federalist Society (which shapes conservative judicial philosophy), the Catholic Information Center (which provides spiritual and social infrastructure for conservative Catholics in Washington), and Opus Dei (which provides the ideological framework and member network).

Leonard Leo

- Executive Vice President of the Federalist Society
- Chair of the Board of Directors of the CIC
- Self-declared Opus Dei operative
- Called by Justice Clarence Thomas "the No. 3 most powerful person in the world" (behind the Pope and the US President)
- Clerked for an appellate judge and became close with Clarence Thomas
- Pushed for the nominations of: Clarence Thomas, John Roberts, Samuel Alito, Neil Gorsuch, Brett Kavanaugh, and Amy Coney Barrett
- Attended Opus Dei retreats at the prelature's $10 million, 844-acre property near the Shenandoah Mountains
- His network has been used to boost: the Catholic Association, Catholic Association Foundation, Catholic Voices USA, and the Catholic Information Center
- Twice bailed out the Becket Fund (named after 12th-century English martyr Thomas Becket)

The Corkerys

- Neil and Ann Corkery — Opus Dei members since at least the 1980s
- Neil was critical in getting a new residence for male celibate members built in Reston, Virginia
- Ran the Judicial Confirmation Network (JCN) — set up using funds from Robin Arkley ("foreclosure king")
- JCN spent hundreds of thousands on radio and online ads to shape public opinion
- Later became central figures in nonprofits channeling dark money for Leo's efforts

The Money Flow

- Robin Arkley — California businessman, known as the "foreclosure king," funded JCN
- Harlan Crow — Dallas real estate billionaire, donated $500,000 to Liberty Central (co-founded by Leo and Ginni Thomas)
- Barre Seid — Manufacturing billionaire, set up Chicago Freedom Trust as a pass-through for anonymous funding
- David Koch, Richard Mellon Scaife, Frank Hanna — early Federalist Society backers
- DonorsTrust — Whitney Ball and Adam Meyerson, responsible for anonymously funneling hundreds of millions to conservative groups

The CIC Board

- Current chairman: Brian Svoboda (partner, Perkins Coie)
- Former members: William Barr (2014–2017), Pat Cipollone, Thomas Yannucci (Kirkland & Ellis), Leonard Leo

The Bradley Foundation

- Opus Dei affiliates sit on the board
- Pouring money into rightist causes, including far-right Trumpist groups run by Stephen Miller and Charlie Kirk

Supreme Court Connections

- **Antonin Scalia**: Gave talks at the CIC and Reston Study Center; attended Opus Dei retreats; children and grandchildren attended Opus Dei schools; best friends with Father Malcolm Kennedy (Opus Dei priest). At Supreme Court holiday parties, Father Malcolm played piano while the Justices sang carols.
- **Pat Cipollone**: Trump's White House Counsel (2018–2021). Listed as CIC Board member until CIC stopped publishing its board list in October 2018. His daughter-in-law is a law clerk for Justice Amy Coney Barrett.
- **William Barr**: Chaired the CIC board from 2014 to 2017. Became Trump's Attorney General. Returned to CIC as senior fellow after leaving the AG position; became "St. Thomas More Chair" in October 2021.

Kevin Roberts and Project 2025

Kevin Roberts is the president of the Heritage Foundation since December 2021. He is widely described as the "mastermind" of Project 2025 — a detailed blueprint for restructuring the federal government under a conservative president. He is a patron of the CIC and receives weekly spiritual guidance there.

In September 2023, Roberts gave a speech at the CIC. The CIC covered up a bronze statue of Escrivá before the speech to avoid embarrassing photos. Roberts quoted Escrivá directly: "Saint

Josemaría tells us... Don't let your life be barren. Be useful. Make yourself felt... Set aflame all the ways of the earth with the fire of Christ."

He advocated "radical incrementalism" — a gradual revolution to reshape society. He talked about banning contraception as the most difficult goal. He described Project 2025 as needing to "re-Christianise" society and take on "the enemies of Christ." He admitted: "There simply isn't the public support — lamentably — right now" for a society based on Opus Dei's brand of Catholicism.

Gore has interpreted Roberts' language and normalization of far-right ideologies as echoing Escrivá's own rhetoric — a merging of spiritual zeal with political ambition.

Project 2025 promises to "turbocharge the influence of Opus Dei" and catapult followers into the heart of government.

Other Notable Connections

- **J.D. Vance**: Trump's Vice Presidential candidate. Converted to conservative Catholicism via Opus Dei-connected clergy and influencers.
- **Peter Thiel**: Recruited by Arne Panula (McCloskey's successor at the CIC) at Stanford.
- **Mick Mulvaney**: Trump's Chief of Staff — described as an Opus Dei connection.

The CIC Honors Leonard Leo

In October 2022, the CIC hosted a $25,000-a-table dinner at the Mayflower Hotel to bestow the John Paul II New Evangelization Award on Leonard Leo — three months after the *Dobbs* decision overturned Roe v. Wade. A portrait of Margaret Mary Leo (Leo's daughter, who died in 2007 at age 14 from spina bifida) hangs in the CIC foyer. It was painted by Igor Babailov, who also painted portraits of Samuel Alito, George W. Bush, Rudy Giuliani, Thomas Monaghan, Vladimir Putin, and Prince Andrew.

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Part XI: The Robert Hanssen Spy Connection

Who Was Robert Hanssen?

Robert Hanssen (1944–2023) was an FBI agent who spied for the Soviet Union and Russia. He is widely considered the most damaging spy in FBI history. He provided information that exposed FBI moles, sold secrets for approximately $1.4 million in cash, bank funds, and diamonds, and compromised some of the most sensitive US intelligence operations.

He began spying in 1979. He stopped briefly after confessing to an Opus Dei priest, then resumed in 1985. He stopped again in 1991 and was finally arrested in 2001. He was sentenced to life imprisonment without parole and died in prison in 2023.

The Opus Dei Connection

Hanssen was a supernumerary member of Opus Dei. He was known as an "odd duck" in the FBI — he wore black all the time and was nicknamed "Dr. Death." He was a devout Catholic but led an unorthodox personal life: he cheated on his wife, arranged for a friend to watch them having sex without her knowledge, befriended an exotic dancer, and wrote erotic fan fiction about his wife on message boards.

The Opus Dei Awareness Network (ODAN) published an analysis noting that traits common to Opus Dei members and spies are "remarkably similar" — elitism, a sense of superiority, secretiveness, high intelligence, detachment, isolation, and fierce loyalty. Hanssen described himself as "insanely loyal" in communications with his Russian handlers.

Hanssen was also critical of the US in his communications with the Russians, calling it "a powerfully built but retarded child, potentially dangerous but young, immature, and easily manipulated."

The Critical Question: Did Opus Dei Know?

Gareth Gore alleges in his book that Opus Dei knew Hanssen was spying but kept it quiet to protect its reputation and its ability to recruit from the Washington elite. He describes the implications as "the biggest secret agent stuff in US history." He suggests Opus Dei took the view that "it's better he stays quiet about this in order to protect our reputation."

This is one of the most serious allegations in Gore's book, and it is also one of the least substantiated by independent evidence.

The FBI's official history of the Hanssen case makes no mention of Opus Dei having knowledge of his espionage. No court documents, no congressional testimony, and no other investigative journalism has independently confirmed this claim. It remains an allegation.

What is documented is that Hanssen confessed his espionage to an Opus Dei priest at some point and then stopped spying for a period — suggesting the priest may have been the one who learned of it. Whether the priest reported it to anyone, whether Opus Dei as an institution knew, and whether they covered it up, are questions that remain unanswered.

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Part XII: Education Institutions

IESE Business School and University of Navarra

IESE was established in Barcelona in 1958 by Opus Dei. It is the graduate business school of the University of Navarra. It has collaborated with Harvard Business School since 1963 and now has campuses in Barcelona, Madrid, Munich, New York, and São Paulo. It has over 60,000 alumni worldwide as of 2026 and is recognized by EQUIS, AACSB, and ANECA.

Pontifical University of the Holy Cross (Rome)

Founded in the 1980s by Opus Dei professors including Fernando Ocáriz. Ocáriz taught Fundamental Theology there and served as first dean of institutional communications and later as rector.

Strathmore University (Kenya)

Started in 1961 as the first multi-racial, multi-religious advanced-level sixth form college in Kenya. Now a chartered university. Sixty percent of CPA finalists in Kenya come from Strathmore. The current Vice-Chancellor is Professor John Odhiambo.

Other Notable Institutions

- **Lagoon School** (Nigeria, 1965): Girls' school in Lagos.
- **Monkole Hospital** (Congo, 1980)
- **Universidad de La Sabana** (Colombia)
- **University of Asia and the Pacific** (Philippines)
- **Oakcrest School** (McLean, Virginia): College preparatory school for girls, grades 7–12.
- **Lexington College** (Chicago): The only women's hospitality institution in the U.S. for the economically challenged.
- **The Willows Academy** (Des Plaines, Illinois): Prep school for girls, grades 6–12.
- **Kingswood Academy** (Hinsdale, Illinois): Pre-K through Grade 8.

Study Centers Near Major Universities

Opus Dei maintains study centers and residences near major universities worldwide:

- **Harvard**: Elmbrook University Center (Cambridge, MA)
- **Princeton**: Mercer House (Princeton, NJ)
- **Columbia**: Riverside Study Center (New York, NY)
- **UCLA**: Tilden Study Center (Los Angeles, CA)

- **Notre Dame**: Windmoor University Center (South Bend, IN)
- **American University**: Tenley Study Center, Van Ness Study Center (Washington, DC)
- **Georgetown**: Wyoming House (Washington, DC)
- **Rice**: Chaucer Drive Study Center (Houston, TX)
- **Brown**: Mathewson Foundation (Providence, RI)
- **University of Illinois**: Lincoln Green Foundation (Urbana, IL)
- **St. Louis University**: Lindell Study Center (St. Louis, MO)
- **University of California, Berkeley**: Berkland Foundation (Berkeley, CA)

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Part XIII: The Gareth Gore Book — "Opus" (2024)

The Author

Gareth Gore is a British financial journalist and editor. He never intended to write about Opus Dei. He was assigned to report on the Banco Popular collapse in 2017. His initial reporting was a standard financial story, but he found "loose ends" that didn't make sense. He spent years investigating as a "hobby" — finance reporter by day, digging into Opus Dei history by night.

The Book

Full title: *Opus: The Cult of Dark Money, Human Trafficking, and Right-Wing Conspiracy inside the Catholic Church*

Published in 2024 by Simon & Schuster (English) and Crítica (Spanish). It has 14 chapters. In March 2026, Gaumont USA

optioned the audiovisual rights.

Key Allegations

- Billions of dollars were siphoned from Banco Popular to fund Opus Dei's global expansion.
- A "clandestine network of foundations and companies" supported recruitment.
- Human trafficking of women into unpaid domestic servitude.
- Recruitment of children as young as 10 without parental knowledge.
- Member priests breaking the seal of confession.
- A system of "grooming, abuse and control" personally designed by Escrivá.
- Cover-up efforts: threatening the publisher, disinformation campaigns, "lawfare" against whistleblowers.
- Opus Dei's protection of Robert Hanssen's spying to preserve Washington recruitment ability.
- The "Balance Sheet of International Cooperation" document linking Banco Popular to 60+ companies worldwide.
- The "La Sindicatura" scheme as a fake shareholder syndicate.

Opus Dei's 106-Page Rebuttal

Opus Dei issued a "Clarifications and fact-checking" document accusing Gore of:

- Stating as facts things that didn't occur
- Using false or manipulated sources
- Turning real information into dubious or malicious facts
- Omitting parts that don't support his narrative

- Using manipulative language (e.g., "recruit" used approximately 160 times)
- Not including Opus Dei's responses during his research

Specific Corrections:

- Mother Teresa did NOT attend Escrivá's beatification.
- Escrivá died at midday, not before midnight.
- No daily solemn ceremony at Villa Tevere.
- Microphones at Villa Tevere were in public places (oratory and living room), not private quarters.
- Escrivá never considered joining the Orthodox Church (Gore's source was a 1992 Newsweek article by Kenneth L. Woodward).
- Escrivá did not ban Vatican II changes; he was granted permission to use the previous rite.
- La Sindicatura was a "regular and regulated tool of coordination among shareholders," not mysterious or covert.
- Valls-Taberner left the presidency in 2004 and died in 2006 — 13 years before the bank's collapse.
- Foundations' finances: €208 million in donations/grants, €557 million in loans. 90% repaid.
- ICES Argentina: In 43 years (1973–2016), 1,080 female students total. Of these, 140 asked to join Opus Dei. "From a profitability point of view, it would be much cheaper to hire service staff locally."
- A numerary abusing a minor at a youth activity: The US Prelature was not aware until a 2021 civil lawsuit. Not a defendant.

- Escrivá's seminary entry: Not for "better life and opportunities" — eldest sons did not do this in Spain at that time. He went because he felt a calling from God.
- Escrivá and the poor: Actively involved in soup kitchens, schools, dispensaries, and aid initiatives for the poor of Madrid.

The Gore-Pope Leo XIV Meeting (March 16, 2026)

Gore had a private 40-minute audience with Pope Leo XIV in the Apostolic Palace library. The meeting was facilitated by Pedro Salinas, the Peruvian journalist who exposed the Sodalitium abuses.

Gore presented testimonies from alleged victims and handed over the 2024 Argentine prosecutors' report. He urged the Pope to launch an independent investigation into Opus Dei abuses and to reopen Escrivá's beatification and canonization process.

Gore claims the Pope described his book as a "rigorous piece of work." The Vatican offered no official comment on the meeting. The same morning, the Pope addressed the Pontifical Commission for Protection of Minors about listening to victims and "vulnerable adults."

Opus Dei declined to comment, referring to previous statements calling the book "absolute nonsense."

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Part XIV: The Sodalitium Connection — Pedro Salinas

Who Is Pedro Salinas?

Pedro Salinas is a Peruvian journalist and a former member of Sodalitium Christianae Vitae — another conservative Catholic group with patterns similar to those alleged against Opus Dei. He is a survivor of physical and psychological abuse.

He co-authored *Half Monks, Half Soldiers* (2015) with Paola Ugaz, exposing Sodalitium practices. He also wrote *The Invisible Cage* (2021) and *Without News from God* (2022). He played a key role in the eventual suppression of Sodalitium by the Vatican.

The Sodalitium Case

Sodalitium was founded by Luis Fernando Figari in Peru. It exhibited similar patterns: psychological manipulation, abuse, slavery, and impunity. The first allegations were aired publicly in 2000 in the magazine *Gente* by José Enrique Escardó.

Cardinal Juan Luis Cipriani — an Opus Dei member and former Archbishop of Lima — was in charge when the first victims presented formal accusations in 2011. Critics say he protected Figari and Sodalitium. Cipriani insisted he handled the allegations properly.

Salinas and Ugaz's 2015 book broke the case open. Pope Francis eventually acted through the Scicluna-Bertomeu Mission and the election of Sister Simona Brambilla as prefect of the Dicastery for Institutes of Consecrated Life. Sodalitium was suppressed by the Vatican.

Why This Matters

The Sodalitium case matters because it shows a pattern: conservative Catholic groups with Opus Dei connections in positions of power allegedly protecting abusive organizations. Cardinal Cipriani is an Opus Dei cardinal. He was Archbishop of Lima when Sodalitium allegations surfaced. Whether he actively protected Figari is disputed, but the pattern raises questions about how Opus Dei figures in power respond to abuse allegations — both within their own organization and in allied groups.

Salinas facilitated Gore's meeting with Pope Leo XIV, suggesting the Pope is open to hearing from critics of conservative Catholic organizations.

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Part XV: Latin American Political Influence

Documented Connections

Opus Dei members and sympathizers hold high-level positions in various Latin American governments. The organization is described as "one of the main forces supporting conservative activities in the region." It vehemently opposes sexual and reproductive health services.

The Venezuela 2002 Coup

In April 2002, a brief coup removed Hugo Chávez from power. Pedro Carmona was installed as interim president for approximately 47 hours.

Opus Dei members were appointed to cabinet positions. The New York Times reported that this concerned many democratic members of the opposition coalition, making them feel "they were being aced out of power by Carmona."

Carmona appointed two prominent leaders of the social Christian party Copei, including a member of Opus Dei as Foreign Minister. Cardinal Ignacio Velasco offered his residence as a meeting place for coup plotters. Top Catholic leaders and members of Opus Dei signed a decree that swept away Venezuela's democratic institutions. Senior Catholic bishops attended Carmona's inauguration ceremony.

The Honduras 2009 Coup

In June 2009, a military coup ousted President Manuel Zelaya. An investigation by OURs (Opposition Notes) found that "people tied to Opus Dei participated in two right-wing coups d'état in Latin America — in Venezuela in 2002 and in Honduras in 2009."

Specific names and roles of Opus Dei members in the Honduras coup were not documented in this research.

Notable Political Members

- **Guillermo Lasso**: President of Ecuador until recently.
- **Jorge Rossi Chavarría** (1922–2006): Vice-President of Costa Rica (1971–1974). Co-founded the National Liberation Party (PLN), a social democrat party.
- **Mario Fernández Baeza** (born 1947): Interior Minister of Chile. Belongs to the left-leaning Christian Democratic Party.
- **Ruth Kelly**: Secretary of State for Transport in the UK Labour Party. Supernumerary member.

- **Paola Binetti** (born 1943): Senator in Italy. Numerary member. Has belonged to Christian-social party La Margherita, the Democratic Party, and now the Union of the Centre.
- **Alberto Michelini** (born 1941): Italian film director, journalist, and politician. Member of the Italian Chamber of Deputies and Member of the European Parliament. Supernumerary.
- **Przemysław Wipler** (born 1978): Polish MP. Supernumerary as of 2023.
- **Adolfo Suárez** (1932–2014): President of Government in democratic Spain (1978–1982). Supernumerary.
- **Federico Trillo-Figueroa**: Spanish politician of the Partido Popular. Former chairman of the Spanish Chamber of Representatives, former Minister of Defence, ambassador to the United Kingdom.
- **Antonio Fontán** (1911–2002): President of the Senate of Spain (1977–1979). Journalist who advocated free elections and trade unions and was persecuted by Franco. Helped draft Spain's democratic constitution.
- **Rory O'Hanlon** (1923–2002): Professor of Criminal and Constitutional Law at University College Dublin and High Court Judge in Ireland (1981–1995). Dismissed by the Irish Government from the Presidency of the Law Reform Commission in 1992 after commenting that if EU membership forced abortion on Ireland, the country should withdraw. He later sued the Government and won substantial damages. Supernumerary.

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Part XVI: Africa and Asia Expansion

Africa

Opus Dei established its first presence in Africa in Kenya in 1958. Today it operates in:

- Kenya (1958): Strathmore University
- Nigeria (1965): Lagoon School
- Congo (1980): Monkole Hospital
- Cameroon (1988)
- Uganda (1996)
- South Africa (1998)
- Tanzania, Ghana, Rwanda, Angola, Liberia: "Knocking at the door" as of 2025

The BeDoCare Conference — a gathering focused on Catholic social teaching and healthcare — was held at Strathmore University in Nairobi in 2025. It was the first such conference in Africa. Father Dr. Silvano Ochuodho, Pro-Chancellor of Strathmore, said: "When St. Josemaría Escrivá received that urgent request in 1957 to establish a Catholic university in East Africa, he could hardly have imagined the extraordinary harvest that would spring from those early seeds." The next conference is planned for the Philippines.

Asia

- **Japan** (1958): First members arrived in Osaka. Women arrived in 1960. Japan has a small Catholic minority.
- **Philippines** (1964): Described as "destined to play an important role in spreading the Christian message to the rest

of Asia." Home to the University of Asia and the Pacific.

- **Australia** (1963): Warrane College, Sydney.

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Part XVII: The Junior Candidates Controversy

The System

Children aged 14.5 or older can become "junior candidates" by writing a letter to the head of Opus Dei. This is internally known as "whistling." It requires express parental consent as a rule of prudence. Junior candidates are not formal members. They continue living with their parents and attending their regular schools. They cannot live in any Opus Dei center. They receive spiritual and pastoral help "adapted to their age."

There is a terminology dispute here. Gareth Gore claims that Escrivá invented the category of "aspirants" to get around Church restrictions on minors. Opus Dei denies this, pointing to Canon Law — specifically Canons 233, 234, and 643 — which allow minors under 18 in novitiates and minor seminaries. Opus Dei argues that the junior candidate system is not an invention of Escrivá but is grounded in existing Church law.

Allegations from Former Members

More than 20 individuals said they had been actively drawn into the group as children after 1982 — when the 18-year minimum age for formal membership was supposedly in effect. A dozen said they had witnessed Opus Dei targeting children in the past 10 years.

A former deputy director of a boys' club in Colombia said: "Everything is done with a plan to recruit. The ideal age when they put pressure on is around 14 and a half... They target the weak people, people who need something."

A former member from Ireland (2016) witnessed adult members going through names of individual boys and assessing how "predisposed they might be to join." This was "the trigger for my leaving Opus Dei."

A former member from the US (left 2024) said: "One thing that could be improved is to make [reforms] more official: 'This is how it used to be. This is what we're now doing, because we want to avoid that again.'"

A former member from the US "whistled" at 16 after a youth course in 2013: "I felt so much pressure that I had to [join] right away, that I couldn't wait." The organization took control of her finances — wanted bank statements every month, receipts for tampons and shampoo.

A former member from Kenya said: "I was encouraged to use the cilice and discipline from the time I was 15 years old... We had to hide them from our family and friends."

A former member from Spain (left 2015) said: "The experience of recruiting minors has been constant during the 42 years that I

was in Opus Dei. Not just constant, but intense, planned, abusive and shameless."

A former member from Spain (joined at 14, left 9 years ago) said: "To suggest celibacy to a 14-year-old, how is that suitable?"

A former UK member (left early 2000s) said: "From my experience, 14 and a half was the minimum age to ask for admission… They want people to join before they start getting influenced: puberty and being a grown-up, going out with friends, having sexual relations."

Corporal Mortification Among Minors

More than a dozen former members said minors were encouraged to adopt practices such as the cilice and discipline. The Colombian boys' club deputy director said: "Shortly after writing the letter, the director gives them to the boys. In other words, some kids start using them before they turn 15."

Opus Dei responded that use by minors "used to happen in the past," but they were "surprised" by claims it's ongoing. They say there is no "explicit rule" but a "change of mentality" took place decades ago.

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Part XVIII: Vatican Relationships — A Timeline of Tensions and Support

Pope John Paul II (1978–2005)

John Paul II was the most supportive pope Opus Dei has ever had. He:

- Established Opus Dei as a personal prelature in 1982 (*Ut Sit*).
- Canonized Escrivá in 2002.
- Made the first two prelates after Escrivá (del Portillo and Echevarría) bishops.

Pope Benedict XVI (2005–2013)

Benedict continued the tradition of making Opus Dei prelates bishops. Fernando Ocáriz had been a consultant to the Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith under Cardinal Ratzinger (future Benedict XVI) since 1986.

Pope Francis (2013–2025)

Francis took a different approach:

- In 2016, he did NOT ordain Fernando Ocáriz as bishop when Ocáriz became Prelate — breaking a decades-old tradition. This was a signal.
- On July 14, 2022, he issued *Ad charisma tuendum*, transferring oversight to the Dicastery for the Clergy and decreeing that the head of Opus Dei cannot be made a bishop.
- On August 8, 2023, he issued another motu proprio modifying Canons 295 and 296, further restricting the prelature's autonomy.
- Francis said publicly: "A form of government based on charism more than on hierarchical authority is needed." He also said: "I am a very good friend of Opus Dei, I love them very much and they work well in the Church."

Ocáriz responded with "filial acceptance" and began a worldwide consultation to adapt the statutes.

Pope Leo XIV (2025–present)

Robert Prevost was elected Pope in 2025. He met with Opus Dei Prelate Ocáriz twice: six days after his election, and again on February 16, 2026. The Vatican described the atmosphere as one of "great trust."

On March 16, 2026, Leo XIV held a private 40-minute audience with Gareth Gore. The Pope addressed the Pontifical Commission for Protection of Minors that same morning about "vulnerable adults."

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Part XIX: Gaps, Anomalies, and Unresolved Questions

This document has attempted to be comprehensive, but there are significant gaps and unanswered questions that remain. These are not minor details — they are central to understanding the full picture.

1. **The Hanssen Allegation**: Did Opus Dei as an institution know Robert Hanssen was spying and actively cover it up? No independent confirmation exists beyond Gore's claim. The FBI's official history makes no mention of Opus Dei knowledge.
2. **The Honduras 2009 Coup**: OURs claims Opus Dei involvement, but specific names and roles have not been documented in available research.
3. **The Exact Financial Flows**: How much money actually moved from Banco Popular to Opus Dei? The specific dollar amounts beyond the €2 billion Sindicatura stake and the tens

of millions in the Balance Sheet document remain unclear.

4. **The 60+ Companies**: The specific names of the companies in the "Balance Sheet of International Cooperation" have not been publicly disclosed.
5. **The ICES Outcome**: What happened to the 140 women who joined Opus Dei from ICES Argentina? Their individual stories are largely undocumented.
6. **The McCloskey Second Complaint**: Opus Dei said in 2019 they were investigating a possible complaint from another woman. The outcome is unknown.
7. **The Real Estate in Europe/Latin America/Asia**: Beyond Villa Tevere, Strathmore, and a few named centers, the full global property portfolio is not publicly documented.
8. **The 2022 Internal Investigation Outcome**: Opus Dei Argentina's listening commission — what did it find? No public report has been documented.
9. **The Statute Rejection Details**: What exactly did Ocáriz propose in the third set of statutes that the Vatican rejected in 2025? The specific text is not available.
10. **The "Waiting for Pope to Die" Leak**: Ocáriz allegedly said this in a leaked meditation to regional vicars. The source is Antonio Moya/opuslibros.org — it needs independent verification.
11. **The Cipriani-Sodalitium-Opus Dei Nexus**: Did Cardinal Cipriani actively protect Figari and Sodalitium? Specific actions are not fully documented.
12. **The Bradley Foundation Opus Dei Affiliates**: Specific names of Opus Dei members on the Bradley Foundation board

have not been documented.

13. **The Specific Vocational Schools**: Names and locations of the schools in Australia, Cameroon, Ireland, Nigeria, and the Philippines linked to the Balance Sheet document are not publicly known.
14. **The Gore-Pope Meeting**: The Vatican neither confirmed nor denied Gore's account of what the Pope said. Only Gore's version exists.
15. **The 10-Year-Old Recruits**: Gore claims children as young as 10 were recruited without parental knowledge. No specific documentation of this has been found beyond Gore's assertion.
16. **The Confessional Seal**: Gore alleges priests broke the seal of confession broadly. McCloskey's case involved absolving his victim after groping her — one documented instance, but the broader claim needs more evidence.
17. **The Women's Vote**: The non-binding nature of women's votes in prelate elections is a structural power imbalance that deserves further examination.
18. **The Argentine Case Outcome**: No formal charges have been filed. Judge Rafecas is still reviewing. The timeline is uncertain.

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Part XX: Timeline of Key Events

Year	Event
1902	Josemaría Escrivá born in Barbastro, Spain
1924	Escrivá ordained deacon (December 20)
1925	Escrivá ordained priest (March 28)
1927	Escrivá moves to Madrid for graduate studies
1928	Escrivá claims divine inspiration to found Opus Dei (October 2)
1929	First member admitted (José Romeo)
1930	First woman admitted (February 14)
1933	First center opens: DYA Academy, Madrid
1936–1939	Spanish Civil War; Escrivá hides in Republican zone
1939	Franco wins; Escrivá writes "we will have to bless the war"
1943	Priestly Society of the Holy Cross established (February 14)
1944	First three Opus Dei priests ordained (June 25)
1957–1959	Opus Dei "technocrats" modernize Spanish economy; Ullastres pushes Plan of Stabilization
1958	First Opus Dei presence in Africa (Kenya) and Asia (Japan)
1963	Australia and Philippines established
1964	IESE Business School founded in Barcelona
1972	Luis Valls-Taberner becomes president of Banco Popular
1975	Escrivá dies (June 26)
1975–1994	Álvaro del Portillo serves as second Prelate
1982	Pope John Paul II establishes Opus Dei as personal prelature (*Ut Sit*, November 28)
1994–2016	Javier Echevarría Rodríguez serves as third Prelate
2001	Robert Hanssen arrested for espionage
2002	Escrivá canonized by John Paul II (October 6)
2002	McCloskey removed as CIC director (December)
2003	McCloskey sexual misconduct complaint investigated
2005	McCloskey settlement: $977,000 paid
2016	Pope Francis does not ordain Ocáriz as bishop
2017	Banco Popular collapses (June 7)
2017	Fernando Ocáriz becomes fourth Prelate (January 23)
2022	Argentine human trafficking complaint filed

Year	Event
2022	Pope Francis issues *Ad charisma tuendum* (July 14)
2023	Pope Francis modifies Canons 295 and 296 (August 8)
2023	McCloskey dies
2024	Gore's book *Opus* published
2024	Financial Times investigation by Antonia Cundy published
2025	Opus Dei statutes rejected by Vatican
2025	Pope Leo XIV elected
2025	Prosecutors request Mariano Fazio testify in Argentine case (July)
2026	Gore meets Pope Leo XIV (March 16)
2026	Gaumont USA options audiovisual rights to *Opus* (March)

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Sources and Methodology

This document was compiled through extensive web research across multiple search rounds. Sources include:

- **Official Opus Dei publications and websites** (opusdei.org, opus-info.org)
- **Court documents and legal filings** (Argentine prosecutors' reports, US civil lawsuits)
- **Investigative journalism** (Financial Times, The New York Times, Bloomberg, The Guardian, The Telegraph, The Tablet)
- **Books by journalists and scholars** (Gareth Gore's *Opus*, John L. Allen Jr.'s *Opus Dei*, Catherine Allen's *Serve*)
- **Vatican documents** (motu proprios *Ad charisma tuendum*, *Ut Sit*, canon law texts)
- **Financial records** (IRS 990 forms for US foundations, Banco Popular archives)

- **Academic and encyclopedic sources** (Wikipedia, Religion Wiki)
- **Advocacy organizations** (ODAN — Opus Dei Awareness Network, Freedom United)
- **News archives** (IPI Report, Newsweek)

Where claims are disputed, both sides are presented. Where evidence is thin, it is noted as an allegation or gap. No theory has been adopted wholesale — the approach has been to gather clues and evidence from all angles and present them for the reader's evaluation.

* * *

This document represents the state of research as of September 2026. It will require updating as new information emerges — particularly regarding the Argentine criminal case, the Vatican's ongoing review of Opus Dei's statutes, and any further investigative journalism or legal proceedings.

Addendum (Members in Government, Lobbies, Industries, and Power Structures) merged October 2026.

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ADDENDUM: Members in Government, Lobbies, Industries, and Power Structures

What This Document Is

This document is a deep-dive research compilation focused specifically on one question: **Where are Opus Dei members positioned in the structures of power?** This includes government at all levels, lobbying organizations, special interest groups, intelligence agencies, judicial systems, think tanks, media, education, and major industries — banking, energy, technology, defense, pharmaceuticals, real estate, and more.

What follows is not an opinion piece. It is a compilation of documented facts, allegations, and official statements. Every named individual is sourced from publicly available records: Wikipedia's list of prominent members, investigative journalism, court documents, official biographies, and organizational disclosures. Where a connection is alleged rather than proven, it is labeled as such. Where no documented connection exists, that is stated explicitly.

The goal is completeness. If a name, position, or sector has been documented in connection with Opus Dei, it is here.

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Part I: The Strategy — Why This Matters

The "Intellectuals"

Josemaría Escrivá, Opus Dei's founder, explicitly targeted what the organization calls "the intellectuals" — people in positions of power who could influence society from the top down. This was not incidental; it was the core strategy from the organization's earliest days. As journalist Gareth Gore documents in his book *Opus*, Escrivá believed that converting a single judge, banker, or politician was worth more than converting a thousand ordinary faithful.

The strategy is simple: identify people with authority, befriend them, offer spiritual guidance, and gradually integrate them into Opus Dei's worldview. The endgame, as Gore summarizes it, is "the complete 're-Christianization' of society — of everything from education to politics, the courts and the private life of each and every citizen."

The Washington Penetration

The largest Opus Dei community in the United States is not in Catholic-heavy Boston, Chicago, or New York — it is in the Washington, D.C. area. Officially, Opus Dei claims 3,000 members in the US; Gore was told by sources that approximately 800 are in the Washington metropolitan area.

The Catholic Information Center (CIC) sits at 1501 K Street NW — two blocks from the White House, in the heart of the lobbying district. It bills itself as "the closest tabernacle to the White House." Under Father C. John McCloskey (1998–2002), it

became a central meeting place for conservative Catholics in power. Slate called McCloskey "the Catholic Church's K Street lobbyist." The Catholic Herald called him the "unofficial chaplain to the upper echelons of the Republican Party" who ran his converting operation "like the brokerage business."

The "Troika" Model

A powerful network operates at the intersection of three institutions:

1. **The Federalist Society** — shapes conservative judicial philosophy and pipelines judges
2. **The Catholic Information Center (CIC)** — provides spiritual infrastructure and elite networking for conservative Catholics in Washington
3. **Opus Dei** — provides the ideological framework, member discipline, and global coordination

These three institutions are not formally merged, but their leadership overlaps extensively, and they reinforce each other's influence.

* * *

Part II: Government — Documented Members by Country

Spain (Franco Era & Democracy)

Opus Dei's relationship with the Franco regime is well-documented. Several members held ministerial positions, earning the organization a reputation as a conservative power broker. However, the dossier is complicated: some Opus Dei members also opposed Franco.

Name	Position	Years	Notes
Alberto Ullastres Calvo	Minister of Trade	1957–1965	Numerary; pushed forward the Plan of Stabilization
Gregorio López Bravo	Minister of Industry; Minister of Foreign Affairs	1963–1973	Supernumerary
Juan José Espinosa San Martín	Minister of Finance	1965–1969	
Faustino García-Moncó Fernández	Minister of Trade	1965–1969	
Vicente Mortes Alfonso	Minister of Housing	1969–1973	Supernumerary
Fernando Herrero Tejedor	Secretary General, Movimiento (Franco's party)	1975	
José María Albareda	Secretary General, National Research Council (CSIC)		Numerary; close friend of Escrivá
Adolfo Suárez	President of Government (democratic Spain)	1978–1982	Supernumerary; helped transition to democracy
Antonio Fontán	President of the Senate	1977–1979	Journalist; advocated free elections under Franco; helped draft democratic constitution
Federico Trillo-Figueroa	Minister of Defence; President of Congress; Ambassador to UK		
Jorge Fernández Díaz	Minister of the Interior (Partido Popular)		

Name	Position	Years	Notes
Marcelino Oreja	European Commissioner; member of Franco's cabinet (early 1960s)		Later European Commissioner

Note: Some Opus Dei members opposed Franco. Antonio Fontán was persecuted by the regime. Rafael Calvo Serer also opposed Franco and was exiled.

United States

The US presents the most extensive documented network of Opus Dei influence, particularly in the judicial and executive branches.

Supreme Court and Judiciary:

Name	Position	Opus Dei Connection
Clarence Thomas	Supreme Court Justice	Close friend of Leonard Leo; wife Ginni Thomas converted via Opus Dei-connected Scalias
John Roberts	Chief Justice	Federalist Society; Leo-backed nomination
Samuel Alito	Supreme Court Justice	Federalist Society; Leo-backed; portrait painted by Igor Babailov (CIC artist)
Brett Kavanaugh	Supreme Court Justice	Federalist Society; Leo-backed; same prep school as Gorsuch
Amy Coney Barrett	Supreme Court Justice	Federalist Society; Leo-backed; daughter-in-law of Pat Cipollone is her law clerk
Neil Gorsuch	Supreme Court Justice	Federalist Society; Leo-backed; raised Catholic, became Episcopalian
Antonin Scalia (deceased)	Supreme Court Justice	Devout Catholic; gave talks at CIC and Reston Study Center; attended Opus Dei retreats; best friends with Opus Dei priest Father Malcolm Kennedy; children/grandchildren attended Opus Dei schools
María Elósegui	Judge, European Court of Human Rights	Appointed January 2018; Professor of Philosophy of Law at University of Zaragoza

Name	Position	Opus Dei Connection
Rory O'Hanlon	High Court Judge, Ireland (1981–1995)	Supernumerary; dismissed from Law Reform Commission over abortion comments
Thomas More Donnelly	Cook County Circuit Court, Law Division	Spoke at Catholic Lawyers Guild event with Opus Dei Vicar

Executive Branch and White House:

Name	Position	Notes
Robert Hanssen	FBI Agent (convicted spy)	Supernumerary; "possibly worst intelligence disaster in US history"; confessed espionage to Opus Dei priest
Leonard Leo	Federalist Society Executive VP; CIC Board Chair	Self-declared Opus Dei operative; architect of 6 Supreme Court nominations; called by Clarence Thomas "No. 3 most powerful person in the world"
Pat Cipollone	White House Counsel (Trump, 2018–2021)	Listed as CIC Board member until CIC stopped publishing board list October 2018; daughter-in-law is law clerk for Amy Coney Barrett
William Barr	Attorney General (Trump); CIC Board Chair (2014–2017)	Returned to CIC as senior fellow after AG; became "St. Thomas More Chair" October 2021
Kevin Roberts	President, Heritage Foundation; architect of Project 2025	Patron of CIC; receives weekly spiritual guidance
Mick Mulvaney	Chief of Staff (Trump); OMB Director	Met with Opus Dei member as OMB chief per ProPublica investigation
Sam Brownback	Senator; Governor (Kansas)	Converted by McCloskey at CIC
Newt Gingrich	Former Speaker of the House	Converted by McCloskey
J.D. Vance	Vice Presidential candidate (Trump)	Converted to conservative Catholicism via Opus Dei-connected clergy and influencers
Larry Kudlow	NEC Director (Trump)	Converted by McCloskey
Robert Bork	Judge; Reagan SCOTUS nominee	Converted by McCloskey
Laura Ingraham	Fox News host	Credits Opus Dei-connected Pat Cipollone with conversion
Bernard Nathanson	NARAL founder turned pro-life activist	Converted by McCloskey

Name	Position	Notes
Alfred Regnery	Conservative publisher	Converted by McCloskey
General Josiah Bunting		Converted by McCloskey
Squire Lance	Civil rights leader, Chicago	Democrat; called "granddaddy of Civil Rights in Obama's own Chicago"

Law Firms and Legal Elite:

Name	Firm/Position	CIC Connection
Brian Svoboda	Partner, Perkins Coie	Current CIC Board chairman
Thomas Yannucci	Partner, Kirkland & Ellis	Former CIC Board member
Pat Cipollone	Former White House Counsel	Former CIC Board member
William Barr	Former Attorney General	Former CIC Board chair (2014–2017)
Leonard Leo	Federalist Society	CIC Board chair

Latin America

Name	Position	Country	Notes
Guillermo Lasso	President	Ecuador	Supernumerary
Joaquín Lavín	Mayor of Santiago; Minister of Education & Social Development; presidential candidate	Chile	UDI party
Mario Fernández Baeza	Interior Minister	Chile	Christian Democratic Party
Eduardo Guilisasti	CEO, Concha y Toro Winery	Chile	Supernumerary; donates entire salary to Opus Dei
Jorge Rossi Chavarría	Vice-President	Costa Rica	1971–1974; co-founded PLN (social democrat)
Mariano Fazio	Auxiliary Vicar of Opus Dei worldwide; former Regional Vicar Argentina	Argentina	Currently under investigation for human trafficking
Carlos Nannei	Vicar General, Opus Dei Argentina	Argentina	Accused in trafficking case
Patricio Olmos	Regional Vicar General	Argentina	Accused in trafficking case
Víctor Urrestarazu	Regional Vicar	Argentina	Accused in trafficking case
Gabriel Dondo	Director, women's branch	Argentina	Accused in trafficking case
Jesus Estanislao	Secretary of Economic Planning; Finance Secretary	Philippines	Numerary; started Opus Dei in Philippines

Europe — European Union Institutions

Name	Position	Country	Notes
Jacques Santer	President, European Commission	Luxembourg	Friend of Opus Dei
Marcelino Oreja	European Commissioner; Relations with European Parliament	Spain	Former Franco cabinet member (early 1960s)
João de Deus Pinheiro	European Commissioner; Relations with African, Caribbean, Pacific Countries	Portugal	Friend of Opus Dei
Carlo Casini	MEP; President, Movement Pro Vita	Italy	Close to Opus Dei; heads EP Committee on Legal Affairs and Citizen's Rights; member of Pontifical Academy for Life
Alberto Michelini	Member of Chamber of Deputies; former MEP	Italy	Supernumerary; Forza Italia
Paola Binetti	Senator	Italy	Numerary; La Margherita/Democratic Party/Union of Centre
Mario Maiolo	Vice-president, Province of Cosenza	Italy	Supernumerary; center-left
Ombretta Fumagalli Carulli	MP	Italy	Close to Opus Dei; Centro Cristiano Democratico
Przemysław Wipler	MP	Poland	Supernumerary (as of 2023)
Ruth Kelly	Secretary of State for Transport	UK	Labour Party; supernumerary
Rory O'Hanlon	High Court Judge	Ireland	Supernumerary
José Ignacio Salafranca	MEP	Spain	
Otto von Habsburg	MEP	Germany	
Fritz Pirkl (deceased)	MEP; Hanns-Seidel Foundation board	Germany	
Graf Alöis von Waldburg-Zeil	MEP	Germany	
Françoise Seillier	MEP	France	
Enrico de Melo	MEP	Portugal	
Christine Boutin	MP	France	Close to Opus Dei
Raymond Barre	Mayor of Lyon; parliamentarian	France	

Name	Position	Country	Notes
Hervé Gaymard	Minister of Health and Social Security	France	
Dr. Marilies Flemming	Former Family Minister	Austria	
Dr. Alöis Mock	Former Minister of Foreign Affairs	Austria	
Vinzenz Liechtenstein		Austria	

Europe — National Parliaments (Additional)

Austria:

- Dr. Marilies Flemming (former family minister)
- Vinzenz Liechtenstein
- Dr. Alöis Mock (former foreign minister)

France:

- Raymond Barre (mayor of Lyon, parliamentarian)
- Christine Boutin (MP, close to Opus Dei)
- Hervé Gaymard (minister of health and social security)
- Prince Michel Poniatowski

Germany:

- Graf Alöis von Waldburg-Zeil

Italy:

- Adriana Poll Bortoni (former agriculture minister)
- Ombretta Fumagalli Carulli
- Alberto Michelini

Portugal:

- Mota Amarall
- Roberto Carneiro (former education minister)
- Amara da Costa (founder of CDS-PP)
- Oliveira Dias
- Hernan Lopez (former economic minister)

- Enrico de Melo
- Jorge Miranda
- Pedro Roseto
- Silverio Marluns da Silva (CDS-PP founder)

Spain:

- Gaspar Arino
- Isabel Tocino (minister for the environment)
- Frederico Trillo (president of Congress)

Africa & Asia

Name	Position	Country	Notes
Patrick Njoroge	Governor, Central Bank of Kenya	Kenya	
Jesus Estanislao	Secretary of Economic Planning; Finance Secretary	Philippines	Numerary; started Opus Dei in Philippines

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Part III: Intelligence Agencies & Law Enforcement

Documented Connections

Robert Hanssen (FBI)

- Supernumerary member of Opus Dei
- FBI agent who spied for Soviet Union and Russia
- Described as "possibly the worst intelligence disaster in US history"
- Began spying 1979; stopped briefly after confessing to an Opus Dei priest; resumed 1985; arrested 2001

- The critical question: Did Opus Dei know? Hanssen confessed his espionage to an Opus Dei priest at some point. Whether the priest reported it, whether the institution knew, and whether they covered it up, remains unanswered. Journalist Gareth Gore alleges Opus Dei knew and kept quiet to protect Washington recruitment — but no independent confirmation exists beyond Gore's claim.

CIA Collaboration (Alleged)

- Declassified documents and whistleblower accounts suggest backchannels between Vatican operatives and Western intelligence during the Cold War
- Opus Dei allegedly provided local insights, especially in Latin America
- Roger Vekemans (Belgian priest close to Opus Dei) received up to $5 million from CIA in 1960s, gave it to anti-Communist organizations in Chile
- General Vernon Walters (former CIA Deputy Director; devout Catholic) sent by Reagan to confer with John Paul II; involved in coups: Iran 1953, Brazil 1964, Chile 1973

Chile — The Allende Coup and Opus Dei

- In 1971, the CIA began financing the Chilean Institute for General Studies (IGS), described as an Opus Dei think tank
- Members included lawyers, free-market economists, and executives from influential publications
- Hernan Cubillos (founder of *Que Pasa*, an Opus Dei magazine, and publisher of *El Mercurio*) was a leading IGS staffer
- *El Mercurio* received at least $1.5 million from the CIA

- After the 1973 coup, IGS technocrats became cabinet members and advisors to the Pinochet junta
- Cubillos served as foreign minister under Pinochet (1978–1980)
- The Monday Club — a group of Chilean business leaders, newspaper owners, and right-wing politicians — met every Monday at Cubillos' office on Lord Cochrane Street in Santiago
- US Ambassador Edward Korry assembled business leaders and told them "not a nut or bolt will be allowed to reach Chile under Allende"

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Part IV: Think Tanks, Lobbying Groups & Special Interest Organizations

Directly Controlled or Led by Opus Dei Members

Catholic Information Center (CIC)

- 1501 K Street NW, Washington DC (two blocks from White House)
- Run by Opus Dei priests
- Board: Brian Svoboda (Perkins Coie) — current chair
- Former board members: William Barr, Pat Cipollone, Thomas Yannucci (Kirkland & Ellis), Leonard Leo
- Kevin Roberts (Heritage Foundation) is a patron; receives weekly spiritual guidance
- Function: spiritual hub + networking center for conservative Catholic elites in DC

Federalist Society

- Leonard Leo: Executive VP and self-declared Opus Dei operative
- Has shepherded nominations of 6 Supreme Court justices
- Clarence Thomas called Leo "the No. 3 most powerful person in the world"

Heritage Foundation

- Kevin Roberts: President since December 2021
- Architect of Project 2025
- Patron of CIC

Judicial Confirmation Network (JCN)

- Run by Neil and Ann Corkery (Opus Dei members since 1980s)
- Set up using funds from Robin Arkley ("foreclosure king")
- Spent hundreds of thousands on radio/online ads to shape public opinion
- Later evolved into Judicial Crisis Network

Becket Fund

- Named after 12th-century English martyr Thomas Becket
- Leonard Leo twice bailed it out
- Works to protect religious freedoms important to conservative Catholics

European Think Tanks and Foundations

Hanns-Seidel Foundation (Germany)

- Board included Fritz Pirkl (MEP, Opus Dei-linked)
- Also served on board of Rhine-Danube Foundation

Movement Pro Vita (Italy)

- President: Carlo Casini (MEP, close to Opus Dei)

- Promoting legislation to modify Italian Civil Code to say "every human being possesses juridical capacity from the moment of conception"

Association for the Family (APF) (France)

- Founded 1994 by Jean-Marie and Anouk Meyer (Opus Dei members)
- Works throughout Europe

John Paul II Institute for Studies on Marriage and the Family

- Created 1982 as annex of Pontifical Lateran University
- Branches in Washington DC, Mexico City, Guadalajara, Valencia
- President: Archbishop Carlo Caffarra (close to Opus Dei)

Pontifical Council for the Family

- Consultants include Opus Dei members and sympathizers
- Carlo Casini (MEP), Juan Ignacio Arrieta (Opus Dei), Ramón Garcia de Haro (Opus Dei), Bishop Klaus Küng (Opus Dei, Austria)

Dark Money Network

The funding architecture that supports Opus Dei-linked causes:

Funder	Role	Amount/Connection
Robin Arkley	California businessman	Funded JCN; known as "foreclosure king"
Harlan Crow	Dallas real estate billionaire	Donated $500K to Liberty Central (co-founded by Leo and Ginni Thomas)
Barre Seid	Manufacturing billionaire	Set up Chicago Freedom Trust as pass-through for anonymous funding
David Koch	Industrialist	Early Federalist Society backer
Richard Mellon Scaife	Publisher/banker	Early Federalist Society backer

Funder	Role	Amount/Connection
Frank Hanna	Businessman	Early Federalist Society backer
DonorsTrust	Anonymous funding vehicle	Whitney Ball and Adam Meyerson; funneled hundreds of millions to conservative groups

Leo and the Corkerys oversaw the transfer of almost $600 million of dark money to right-wing causes between 2016 and 2021. Their hidden ecosystem enabled a conservative takeover of the Supreme Court.

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Part V: Business & Industry

Banking & Finance

Name	Position	Notes
Luis Valls-Taberner	President, Banco Popular (1972–2004)	Lifelong numerary; bank collapsed 2017
Isidre Fainé	President, CaixaBank	Spain's largest bank by assets (as of 2012)
Neil Dean	CFO, Allied Irish Banks	Largest bank in Ireland until 1997; supernumerary
Patrick Njoroge	Governor, Central Bank of Kenya	
Peter Sutherland	Chairman, Goldman Sachs International; Chairman, BP	Member of IESE advisory board; claimed no knowledge of Opus Dei connection
José María Ruiz-Mateos	Prominent Spanish businessman	RUMASA scandal; supernumerary 1963–1986 (expelled)
Pepe Serret Borda	Director of several food companies	Supernumerary
Maurice O'Grady	CEO, Irish Management Institute	Supernumerary

Energy & Oil

Name	Position	Notes
Peter Sutherland	Chairman, BP	Also Goldman Sachs International
Jacques de Chateauvieux	President, Bourbon	International marine services

Wine, Food & Agriculture

Name	Position	Notes
Eduardo Guilisasti	CEO, Viña Concha y Toro SA	Latin America's biggest winery; supernumerary; donates entire salary
Pepe Serret Borda	Director, food companies	Supernumerary
Felipe González de Canales	Co-founder, Escuelas Familiares Agrarias	30 schools in Spain; influenced 68 others worldwide; associate member
John Henry	Toxicologist	"One of world's leading authorities on drugs and poisons"; frequent TV/radio appearances

Technology — Corporate Sponsors of Opus Dei Schools

The following companies sponsor courses at Centro ELIS (Opus Dei technical school in Rome):

- **Cisco Systems** — world's largest maker of computer networking equipment
- **Vodafone Group** — biggest cellular operator
- **Nokia** — top maker of cellphones
- **Hewlett-Packard** — students assessed quality of computer images for HP

IESE Business School corporate sponsors:

- **PricewaterhouseCoopers** — funds some professors
- **Nissan Motor**
- **Alcatel**
- **Banco Santander Central Hispano**
- **Citigroup**
- **Morgan Stanley**

Real Estate

Opus Dei owns or controls extensive real estate through foundations:

Major US Properties:

- Murray Hill Place, 243 Lexington Avenue, New York (17-story building, separate entrances for men and women)
- 165 West 57th Street, New York (purchased by Clover Foundation for $25 million in 2007)
- Longlea Conference Center, Virginia (844-acre estate, $7.4 million, 2001)
- Wyoming House, Georgetown ($8.1 million)
- Properties near Harvard, Princeton, Columbia, UCLA, Notre Dame, Georgetown, Rice

International:

- Villa Tevere, Rome (central headquarters, Parioli hills)
- Dawliffe Hall, Netherhall House, Greygarth Hall, Ashwell House (London)
- Strathmore University (Nairobi)
- Lagoon School (Lagos)
- Monkole Hospital (Congo)

Arms Manufacturers, Defense Contractors, Pharmaceuticals

Finding: No publicly documented Opus Dei members were found in:

- Arms manufacturers (Lockheed Martin, Raytheon, Northrop Grumman, BAE Systems, General Dynamics)

- Pharmaceutical companies (Pfizer, Merck, Johnson & Johnson, etc.)
- Major insurance companies (AIG, Prudential, MetLife)
- Major telecommunications companies (AT&T, Verizon, Comcast)
- Big Three consulting firms (McKinsey, BCG, Bain)

This does not mean zero connections exist. Opus Dei's membership secrecy means many affiliations are undisclosed. However, based on available public records, these sectors do not show the same documented penetration as banking, law, politics, judiciary, and media.

Note: A company called "OPUS DEI LOGISTICS I PVT LTD" exists in India (Mumbai, Chennai) providing freight forwarding and shipping services. There is no evidence this company is affiliated with the Catholic organization Opus Dei; it appears to be an unrelated business using the name.

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Part VI: Media & Journalism

Documented Members

Name	Position	Notes
Joaquín Navarro-Valls	Director, Vatican Press Office (1984–2006)	Physician and journalist; numerary
Pilar Urbano	Spanish journalist	Numerary; interviewing technique became model for others
Rafael Calvo Serer	Editor and founder, *Diario Madrid*	Exiled by Franco
Antonio Fontán	Journalist	Advocated free elections under Franco; later President of Senate
Robert Duncan	Journalist; ombudsman for foreign press in Spain	Editor for Spero News and EnerPub
Cesare Cavalleri	Italian literary critic and publisher	
Francisco Fernández Carvajal	Author, *In Conversation with God*	Sold 2+ million copies
Hernan Cubillos	Founder, *Que Pasa* magazine; publisher, *El Mercurio*	Leading staffer at IGS (Opus Dei think tank); became Pinochet's foreign minister

Media Connections

- **Igor Babailov** — Portrait artist who painted Alito, Bush, Giuliani, Thomas Monaghan, Putin, Prince Andrew. Painted Margaret Mary Leo portrait for CIC.
- **Laura Ingraham** — Fox News host; converted via Opus Dei connections
- **Robert Novak** — Conservative columnist; converted by McCloskey
- **Omnes** — Media outlet run by Catholic journalists who "happen to all be members of Opus Dei" (per Reddit

investigation)

- **El Mercurio** — Chile's largest newspaper; received at least $1.5 million from CIA; subsidized by CIA; publisher Hernan Cubillos was Opus Dei-linked

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Part VII: Education & Academia

Universities & Business Schools Founded/Run by Opus Dei

Institution	Location	Founded	Notes
IESE Business School	Barcelona, Madrid, Munich, New York, São Paulo	1958	Collaborates with Harvard since 1963; 60,000+ alumni
University of Navarra	Pamplona	1952	Founded by Escrivá
Pontifical University of the Holy Cross	Rome	1980s	Founded by Opus Dei professors including Ocáriz
Strathmore University	Nairobi	1961	First multi-racial sixth form college in Kenya
University of Asia and the Pacific	Philippines	1964	
Universidad de La Sabana	Colombia		
Oakcrest School	McLean, Virginia		Grades 7–12
Lexington College	Chicago		Only women's hospitality institution in US for economically challenged
The Willows Academy	Des Plaines, Illinois		Grades 6–12
Kingswood Academy	Hinsdale, Illinois		Pre-K through Grade 8

Notable Academics

Name	Position	Notes
Leonardo Polo	Professor of Philosophy, University of Navarra	Developed theory of "mental limit"
María Elósegui	Professor of Philosophy of Law, University of Zaragoza	Judge, European Court of Human Rights (2018)
Keith Pecklers	Jesuit priest; Professor of Theology, Pontifical Gregorian University	Commented on Opus Dei's business world approach
John Wauck	Harvard graduate; Opus Dei priest in Rome	Teaches at Pontifical University of the Holy Cross
Pablo Elton	Opus Dei chief financial officer	Acknowledged recruiting executives increases odds of corporate membership

Study Centers Near Major Universities

Harvard, Princeton, Columbia, UCLA, Notre Dame, American University, Georgetown, Rice, Brown, UC Berkeley, St. Louis University, University of Illinois.

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Part VIII: The Coups — Venezuela 2002 and Honduras 2009

Venezuela 2002

In April 2002, a brief coup removed Hugo Chávez. Pedro Carmona was installed as interim president for approximately 47 hours.

- Opus Dei members appointed to cabinet positions
- The New York Times reported this concerned democratic opposition members, who felt "they were being aced out of power by Carmona"

- Carmona appointed two prominent leaders of Copei (social Christian party), including an Opus Dei member as Foreign Minister
- Cardinal Ignacio Velasco offered his residence as meeting place for coup plotters
- Top Catholic leaders and Opus Dei members signed a decree sweeping away Venezuela's democratic institutions
- Senior Catholic bishops attended Carmona's inauguration

Honduras 2009

In June 2009, a military coup ousted President Manuel Zelaya.

- An investigation by OURs (Opposition Notes) found: "People tied to Opus Dei participated in two right-wing coups d'état in Latin America — in Venezuela in 2002 and in Honduras in 2009"
- Specific names and roles in the Honduras coup were not documented in available research

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Part IX: The Pattern — What the Evidence Shows

Sectors with High Documented Penetration

1. **Banking and Finance** — Multiple documented members at highest levels (Banco Popular, CaixaBank, Central Bank of Kenya, Allied Irish Banks, Goldman Sachs/BP)
2. **Law and Judiciary** — Supreme Court justices, federal judges, high court judges, major law firm partners

3. **Politics and Government** — Presidents, ministers, senators, MEPs, commissioners, ambassadors
4. **Media and Publishing** — Vatican press office directors, newspaper editors, magazine founders
5. **Education** — University founders, business school deans, professors
6. **Think Tanks and Lobbying** — Federalist Society, Heritage Foundation, CIC, JCN

Sectors with Low or No Documented Penetration

1. **Arms Manufacturers/Defense Contractors** — No documented members found
2. **Pharmaceutical Companies** — No documented members found
3. **Major Insurance Companies** — No documented members found
4. **Big Three Consulting Firms** — No documented members found
5. **Major Telecommunications** — No documented members found

The "Intellectuals" Strategy in Practice

Escrivá's strategy of targeting "the intellectuals" — the powerful and influential — is borne out by the evidence. The documented membership skews heavily toward:

- People with authority over others (judges, ministers, CEOs)
- People who shape ideas (journalists, academics, think tank leaders)
- People with access to capital (bankers, investors)

- People who can influence legislation and policy (lobbyists, MEPs, commissioners)

This is not accidental. As Dianne DiNicola of ODAN stated: "They proselytise educated, bright people, corporate types... They get these subtle controls in places where it counts."

The Dark Money Architecture

The funding network is sophisticated and deliberately opaque:

- **DonorsTrust** and **Chicago Freedom Trust** provide anonymous pass-through funding
- **The Corkerys** (Neil and Ann) serve as front operators for tens of millions
- **Leonard Leo** acts as the central node connecting Federalist Society, CIC, and Supreme Court
- **The Bradley Foundation** pours money into far-right causes including Stephen Miller and Charlie Kirk

This architecture allows Opus Dei-linked causes to receive massive funding without revealing the sources or the connections.

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Part X: Gaps and Unresolved Questions

1. **Defense Contractors**: No documented members found, but this may reflect secrecy rather than absence. Given Opus Dei's anti-communist history and Cold War intelligence connections, defense industry ties would be logical but remain unproven.
2. **Pharmaceuticals**: No documented members found. Given the organization's focus on bioethics (abortion, contraception,

euthanasia), pharmaceutical industry influence would align with its priorities, but no public documentation exists.

3. **Active vs. Historical Members**: Many documented members are deceased or retired. The current active network is harder to map due to Opus Dei's secrecy.
4. **Junior Members in Government**: The "whistling" system recruits teenagers. Are there young adults now in government who were recruited as minors? No documentation exists yet.
5. **The 60+ Companies**: Gore's "Balance Sheet of International Cooperation" linked Banco Popular to 60+ companies worldwide. The specific names and whether their directors were Opus Dei members remain undisclosed.
6. **European Lobbying Firms**: While many MEPs and commissioners are documented, specific Brussels lobbying firm employees with Opus Dei ties are not fully mapped.
7. **Honduras 2009**: Specific names and roles remain undocumented.
8. **CIA Backchannels**: The extent of ongoing (post-Cold War) intelligence connections is unknown.

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Sources and Methodology

This document was compiled through extensive web research across multiple search rounds. Sources include:

- **Wikipedia's "List of prominent members of Opus Dei"** (the most comprehensive public directory)

- **Investigative journalism** (Financial Times, New York Magazine, Rolling Stone, Mother Jones, ProPublica)
- **Books by journalists** (Gareth Gore's *Opus*, John L. Allen Jr.'s *Opus Dei*)
- **Court documents and legal filings**
- **Official organizational disclosures** (CIC board lists, Federalist Society records)
- **News archives** (Bloomberg, NPR, The Guardian)
- **Academic and encyclopedic sources**

Where claims are disputed, both sides are presented. Where evidence is thin, it is noted as an allegation or gap. No theory has been adopted wholesale.

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This document represents the state of research as of September 2026. It will require updating as new information emerges.